

HARVESTING

Pick young leaves as soon as they are large enough to use. Leaves should be ready within a couple of months. Salad plants reach maturity quickly, after which they become coarse and bitter, with tough stems.

If you are growing your crops for cut-and-come-again salads, keep harvesting the leaves a few at a time, working your way through the successive sowings. Picking encourages the plants to produce more leaves. Just one small batch could supply you with harvests over several weeks.

You can also cut a whole plant while it is still young. The stump left behind will rapidly grow another crop of leaves. Once a plant has bolted, its leaves will no longer be useful, so pull it up.

STORING

Once harvested, salad greens are best used almost immediately, as they soon lose freshness. The leaves do not freeze well, because they become mushy when thawed. However, repeated cropping means that storing salad greens will not be necessary. If you happen to pick more leaves than you need, they will keep for a short while if wetted and kept in a plastic bag in the refrigerator.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Pest damage and infections can destroy tender salad crops. Stay vigilant for signs of trouble.

- Slugs and snails can rapidly demolish a row of seedlings. Deter them with barriers and traps, use nematodes as a biological control, or hunt for them at night and pick them off by hand.
- Arugula in particular is susceptible to attack by flea beetles, which chew holes in leaves. Cover plants with fleece or fine mesh to help deter these and other pests such as cabbage root fly and caterpillars, which target Oriental brassicas.
- Downy mildew is a disease that causes a fluffy white mold to develop on leaves. It is common in plants grown under cover. Pull off the leaves and improve air circulation.



Snails can rapidly demolish leafy salad crops so use defenses to keep them at bay. Ensure that you wash leaves thoroughly before use.